

Yet as we will see in Chapter 2, the scientific literature is clear that we cannot continue growing the global economy without overshooting planetary boundaries. If we keep using more and more resources, we're likely to overheat the planet and collapse the environment. You can't burn the walls of your house to keep yourself warm. Capitalism is just one of several societies humanity has created, and it has to be drawn to a close.

A growing consensus around degrowth is developing as the evidence piles up. Scores of studies and reports are demonstrating that worldwide economic growth is no longer viable. In 2023, a survey of nearly 800 climate policy researchers from around the world found that 73% of respondents deem worldwide economic growth to be incompatible with environmental sustainability.³

But capping economic growth leaves us with a moral problem. How do we alleviate global poverty if we stop growing the global economy? Over half the world's people live *under* a meager poverty line of \$7.40 per day—the amount needed to achieve normal life expectancy. What do those of us with a decent standard of living say to the billions living under the poverty line, or those living in shacks? You're stuck with this life forever?

As we'll see in later chapters, there *is* enough to go around for everyone, but only if we spread it equally. There are 8 billion people alive today, and the global economy produces a little over \$100 trillion per year. Under perfect equality, that leaves about \$80,000 of income for a family of four. However, according to environmental scientists, we likely need to *reduce* the present level of material consumption, which would leave us with even less. If we want all 8 billion people to enjoy a decent standard of living that stays within planetary boundaries, we need to get rid of inequality between and within countries. The environment and human equality are fundamentally linked, and we need to stop treating people and nature like objects for self-gratification.

Thus, we need to reconstruct our societies so that they are *designed* to produce economic, political, and social equality. That means temporary growth in consumption for the global poor and a reduction in standards of living for those above the fair and sustainable limit, accompanied by a change in lifestyle based on less consumption, fewer working hours, and a more pleasant, socially harmonious society.